



accepted the job,” Vinod says.

While working with NCR, Vinod came across a person from Bell Labs, which is considered the Mecca of research in the USA. “That person had a great liking for me. He taught me everything about research, invention, and innovation. Together, we created a leading edge non-volatile memory, the precursor to today’s flash technology used for storing photos in iPhones. We co-authored papers and patents,” Vinod recalls.

While presenting such a work paper on the novel non-volatile memory on behalf of NCR Micro-electronics at an IEEE workshop in Monterey, California, Vinod met Bill Johnson, a director at Intel. Bill was quite impressed with his presentation. He offered Vinod a job at Intel and the rest is history.

Becoming ‘Father of the Pentium Chip’

In 1979, Vinod began his journey at Intel as an engineer in the non-volatile memory team to co-invent Intel’s first flash memory (ETOX) along with other two team members he lead. However, his aspiration was to become a general manager rather than continue with R&D work. Thus, he moved to Intel’s business side by joining a task force to manufacture Intel 386 microprocessors. Unfortunately, Intel 386 was yielding a mere half a good die per wafer with a potential of 50 dies on the 15cm (6-inch) wafer. This issue was a big threat to Intel, since its competitor Motorola was already in high volume production.

Vinod worked as a part of the task force under Craig Barret, who later went on to become CEO and Chairman of Intel. The task force successfully pointed out flaws in the way the silicon process was archi-



Vinod Dham, Founder & MD, Indo US Venture Partners, called on the Prime Minister Narendra Modi in New Delhi on January 16, 2016

tected. Vinod’s contributions to this very important success in enabling ramp up of Intel 386 catapulted him to manage Intel 386 compaction, a follow on to Intel 386, and then take over Intel 486 design mid-stream and make it one of the most successful products, putting Intel on the top.

Vinod helped built a multi-billion-dollar business for Intel as the general manager of Intel 486 product line, before being requested by then CEO, Andy Grove, to step out to start leading the next-generation Intel microprocessor, internally known as P5—until it was named ‘Pentium’ at its launch. Vinod is known as the ‘Father of the Pentium Chip’ for his contribution to the development of Pentium and making it the most popular microprocessor

“I am quite impressed with the vision Honorable Prime Minister Narendra Modiji has set for the growth of the Indian electronics industry. Ashwini Vaishnawji, Minister of Railways, Communications and Electronics & Information Technology in government of India, and Rajeev Chandrasekhar, Minister of State for Electronics and Information Technology of India are quite serious and have the domain knowledge to lead this effort for carrying out Modiji’s vision. It really inspires me to be part of the team to make this very important mission succeed. It’s a strategic imperative for India. It’s not just nice to have or good-to-have, it is a must-to-have,”

—Vinod Dham

in the world! Thus, a leader was born.

Vinod mentions, “I learned leadership from Andy Grove, who was the leader of Intel. I actually learned from him by watching, observing, and asking. Then, I applied the learning in my own leadership style.

“Though I did not have to create a vision, I saw people like him and Gordon Moore creating the vision for the company and then articulating it in a very

clear, simple way, that even a security guard would know as to what was crucial for success of the company at any given point.”

While describing his success in leading Pentium, Vinod says, “It was extremely challenging, very fulfilling, and game-changing in many ways for me. Not only it gave me world-wide visibility, but it also helped me subsequently in many things that I’ve done since. It gave me enormous confidence to deal with very complex projects and situations. These things are important for discovering your own self, and to know what you are capable of.”

As a leader, Vinod prefers to be very crisp and clear with his team about what they want to accomplish. Then he develops a strategy for accomplishing the same, puts together a plan to support the strategy, and divides the plan into actionable objectives on monthly and quarterly basis. He ensures all team members are on the same page and marching down to the same goal.

Nurturing family life and entrepreneurial dream

Vinod began his family life simultaneously with his journey at Intel. He got married in 1980, just six months after joining Intel. It was an arranged marriage. His wife is from Chandigarh. She was doing her PhD before their marriage. Vinod says, “Since we